THE INTERNATIONAL COURT OF JUSTICE

The International Court of Justice (ICJ) is the principal judicial organ of the United Nations Organization (UNO). It was established in June 1945 by the Charter of the United Nations and began its work in April 1946. The seat of the Court is at The Peace Palace in The Hague (Netherlands).

The Court's role is to settle, in accordance with international law, legal disputes submitted to it by the states and to give advisory opinions on legal questions referred to it by authorized United Nations organs and specialized agencies.

Chapter XIV of the Charter embodies the provisions relating to the composition and functions of the International Court of Justice. Article 92 specifies that the ICJ shall function in accordance with the Annexed Statute, which is based on the Statute of the Permanent Court of International Justice (PCIJ) and forms an integral part of the present Charter.

Membership

Article 93 stipulates that all members of the United Nations are *ipso facto* parties to the Statute of the International Court of Justice. It also states that a state, which is not a member of the United Nations, may become a party to the Statute of the International Court of Justice on conditions to be determined in each case by the General Assembly upon the recommendation of the Security Council.

Under Article 95, nothing in the present Charter shall prevent members of the United Nations from entrusting the solution of their differences to other tribunals by virtue of agreements already in existence or which may be concluded in the future.

Composition

The ICJ is composed of fifteen judges elected for a term of nine years by the concurrent vote of the UNGA and the Security Council. These organs vote simultaneously but separately and in order to get elected, a candidate has to secure maximum votes from both the bodies.